



magazine

backpage
Homo Faber in Venice
and human agency

GO TO » PAGE 8

WIDE ANGLE
Devdutt Pattanaik on what
Krishna means to India

GO TO » PAGE 6

LITERARY REVIEW
Indologist David Shulman's
notes from West Bank

GO TO » PAGE 3

Track the latest stories via #ThMagazine on Instagram and X (formerly Twitter)

Get connected » www.thehindu.com

Crisis at hand (Clockwise from right) Buyers check *khoya* at a Delhi shop; an Equinox Lab test; destroying synthetic milk during a raid in Vellore; sampling spices; an installation at a carnival in Goa. (KAMAL NARANG; EQUINOX LABS; D. GOPALAKRISHNAN AND GETTY IMAGES)



Dipanjana Sinha

When Bikaner-based graphic designer Laxmi Rajpurohit, 22, began noticing changes in the taste, smell and consistency of the milk her family was getting from a big, reputed brand, she suspected foul play and decided to take things in her hands. She had read about simple ways of testing milk at home to check for water, starch or detergent. For instance, an iodine test would reveal starch if the milk turns blue-black. She picked up the water test from the Detect Adulteration with Rapid Test, or DART, programme manual of the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI).

She put droplets of the milk on a sloping surface. "It flowed quickly," she says, "like water instead of leaving a thick white trail." She complained to the company's customer care, who asked her for further information about the product. She hasn't heard back ever since.

Rajpurohit can test a drop of milk at home but the test cannot tell her everything that happened before the packet of milk reached her. It can't tell her if the milk contains an adulterant or is contaminated or if it might fail some food safety standard.

apples, calcium carbide ("masala") ripened mangoes, boric acid powder in maida and rice, and synthetic milk (detergent, urea, caustic soda, refined oils, milk powders, carbonates/bicarbonates, melamine, heavy metals, pesticide residues), fake/analogue paneer, and spurious *ghee* (dairy cream with palm oil and *vanaspati*), the average Indian is sick, cautious, angry and fed up. Milk, in particular, is consumed daily by infants up to the elderly, making its adulteration a widespread public health and consumer safety concern.

Bengaluru-based doctor and food writer Nandita Iyer (@saffrontrail on Instagram) recalls how once an ice cream arrived looking like "some separated liquid or oil". From then on, she has become really cautious. She checks labels carefully, sticks only to brands she trusts, and rarely orders from restaurants now.

Fraud remains invisible
"A home test may indicate some things. It cannot establish that everything else is absent. Moreover, a food laboratory can establish what is present in the sample but not if it is an intentional adulteration," says Nilesch Amritkar, managing director of Envirocare Labs, an FSSAI notified food testing laboratory in Mumbai and Goa.

Enough is enough
Between shiny paraffin-wax-coated

CONTINUED ON
» PAGES 4-5

WHO'S WATCHING WHAT WE EAT?

As adulteration cases pile up, the Indian consumer is confronting a food chain where the risks are often invisible



ELITE MATRIMONY

Where India's Finest Families Meet.
Pioneering Elite Matchmaking Since 2008.

From
Matrimony.com
Group

ELITE BRIDES WANTED

BRAHMIN IYER, 31, 183 cms, Software Professional, MS. Lives in California, USA. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

CHETTIYAR, 34, 180 cms, Businessman. M.Arch. Lives in Chennai. Parents are in business. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

UDAIYAR, 33, 180 cms, Businessman, MIB. Lives in Chennai. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

MUDALIYAR, 31, 175 cms, Software Professional, MS. Lives in Chennai. Parents are in business. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

CHRISTIAN PROTESTANT, 28, 178 cms, Software Professional, MS. Lives in Scotland. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

CHRISTIAN, 28, 175 cms, Software Professional, BE. Lives in Chennai. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448344

ELITE GROOMS WANTED

BRAHMIN IYER, 29, 158 cms, Core Game Designer. B.Sc. Lives in Bangalore. Parents are working Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

CHETTIYAR, 27, 155 cms, Businessman. MA. Lives in Chennai. Family is in Business. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

MUDALIYAR, DIVORCEE, 29, 175 cms, Software Professional. B.E. Lives in Chennai. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

KAMMA, 28, 173 cms, Software Professional, MS. Lives in the USA. Family is in business. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match from the USA. Contact: 6366448343

NADAR, 22, 163 cms. BE. Lives in Madurai. Parents are in business. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

DEVENDRA KULA VELLALAR, 37, 168 cms, Consultant. B.Tech. Lives in Bangalore. Parents are Professionals. Family comes from a distinguished and affluent background. Looking for a like-minded and well-educated match. Contact: 6366448343

THE ELITE PROMISE

1 Lakh+
Elite Families
Served

Dedicated
Relationship
Managers

Guaranteed Matches
Assured Meetings

18+ Years of Elite
Matchmaking
Experience

Personalised
& Confidential
Service

Schedule a Confidential Call 99629 76000 www.elitematrimony.com



IN CONVERSATION

17 YEARS AFTER THE HELP

Author Kathryn Stockett on the nearly two decades it took to write her second novel, and the scrutiny that followed her debut's success

Saurabh Sharma

American novelist Kathryn Stockett's debut novel, *The Help* (2009), became a phenomenal success but her second, *The Calamity Club* (Penguin India), took her 17 years to complete. Set in Mississippi during the decade-long Great Depression and its aftermath, the novel explores a bleak chapter in American history, when government policies included forced-sterilisation programmes and the detention of women deemed "promiscuous" or otherwise considered socially undesirable.

The novel offers a vivid and unsparing portrait of American society at the time through three central characters: 11-year-old orphan Meg Lefleur; her mother, Charlie, who finds herself bearing the brunt of these government schemes; and Birdie Calhoun, who seeks security and stability from her well-off sister Frances, who has married into the wealthy Tarrt family.

While spotlighting the history of women's fight for their rights, Stockett weaves an absorbing narrative, bringing together questions of class, power, family and women's struggle for autonomy. In this conversation, the author discusses why the novel took nearly two decades to write, and how she persevered with it despite the controversy that followed *The Help* (which intensified following the release of the film adaptation starring Viola Davis and Octavia Spencer in 2011; Stockett was criticised, mostly, for telling the story of black women's experiences through a white protagonist). Edited excerpts:



Author Kathryn Stockett; and (top) a poster of the 2011 movie adaptation of her debut novel, *The Help*. (GETTY IMAGES)

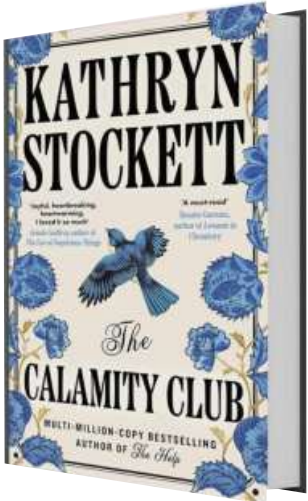
Question: You have spoken about the time it took you to write *The Calamity Club*. Was it because of the pressure that came with the success of *The Help*?
Answer: Let me start by saying, writing *The Help* and *The Calamity Club* were quite different experiences. As a southerner living in New York City 17 years ago, I was terribly homesick. I missed hearing the voices from back home and writing in those voices was the best way I knew to alleviate the feeling. I wrote the story without any expectations (and I faced

60 rejections from agents), so the success of *The Help* certainly took me by surprise, maybe more than anyone else. When I started writing *The Calamity Club*, though, this time it wasn't just me alone in a room curing homesickness; it was me and all those readers and literary critics staring me down. The pressure was paralysing at times. It also didn't serve me that I was intent on writing a book that wouldn't draw the same criticisms that *The Help* did. So, I tried to write a very cautious,

uncontentious story that (unsurprisingly) turned out rather bland. I almost quit altogether, but I didn't want to give up on these characters, especially Meg. The feeling of failure hit hard when my publisher cancelled my contract because I still hadn't turned in a second novel after almost 10 years. I suppose in some ways that set me free. I had nothing to lose, so I rewrote the story with honesty and fearlessness, that confronted many of the same issues that *The Help* did: sexism, racism, and when there was no other choice, laughing at how absurd hypocrisy can be.

Q: What did your research involve? Were there any real incidents that inspired the storyline of *The Calamity Club*?

A: When I set out to write a story, it always starts with the voice, rather than a certain time in history or even a specific place, though I do like to set my stories in Mississippi where I'm from. The characters tend to inform me of when and where they are, and so I start researching much as one would unearth an artefact, as if it were underground, already whole, and it's my job to uncover it.



Once I knew we were in 1933, historical research allowed me to reconstruct the town of Oxford, Mississippi, as it looked then. I went through thousands of photographs, read countless historical accounts, and even interviewed a few folks who remembered this time. So that the reader could feel Mississippi in the 1933, I used juxtaposition. I showed the Tarrts' wealthy lifestyle compared to folks who could barely afford basic necessities; I showed the pristine Ole Miss campus in the 30s, and how every walk of life came together on the square to give the readers a sense of the complexity and fullness of this southern town.

When Birdie, a rural, Mississippi Delta girl, walks around the square for the first time, she passes City Grocery selling vegetables she's never even seen before, she gawks at a new modern contraption on a lady's head in a beauty parlour, and she's surprised, as was I, that so many businesses were doing pretty good in such hard times, in Mississippi, no less. Birdie doesn't fail to notice though, the growing line of men, black and white, leaning on a porch rail, waiting for work that might never come.

Q: If one compares the racism and sexism during the period the novel explores with contemporary times, it would seem little has changed. Would you agree?
A: I agree that racism and sexism are still problems in the U.S., but I would be remiss if I didn't acknowledge how much has changed for the better. That did not come easily, or by accident or simply because times changed. People have fought so hard, dedicating their lives, even giving their lives, for equal rights. When it comes to women's rights, I hope the readers of *The Calamity Club* will realise this: that we cannot take women's rights for granted. What feels permanent can vanish with startling speed – not just here in the U.S., but everywhere. We cannot afford complacency. We must protect what exists, fight for what doesn't yet exist, and refuse to treat either as someone else's responsibility.

The interviewer is a non-binary queer writer, essayist, and culture critic.

Zombies in a time warp

Rejimon Kuttappan's novel explores cyber slavery through the harrowing journey of a young Dalit man from Tamil Nadu

Akila Kannadasan
akila.k@thehindu.co.in

A Dalit fisherman's son from the seaside town of Ramanathapuram in Tamil Nadu sets out for Dubai chasing a better future. John Easow boards a flight from Chennai, armed with a small 'Samsonite knock-off', hoping to crack a graphic designer job interview. But the journey takes him to a dark place instead.

I read Rejimon Kuttappan's novel, *The River of Grey Flowers*, during a low phase in my life. When it takes me into its fold after the first few pages, it feels heavy. But the funny thing is, I could not put it down. This is the kind of novel one just has to finish, no matter what.

The story takes off from a boat ride on a still night along the Moei River that forms a part of the Myanmar-Thailand border. Five people are on board, hanging on to dear life and a thin sliver of hope for survival. They are escapees from a scam compound hidden in the jungles along the border, where men of different nationalities, including Indians, Africans and Chinese, are held prisoners by gun and baton-wielding men.

Their task? To sit in front of computers, using pre-existing scripts to contact and defraud people. Behind fake profiles, the men slog away online, chatting up lonely men and tricking them into making financial investments. If they fail to meet their targets, they face the worst forms of punishment.

Inspired by life

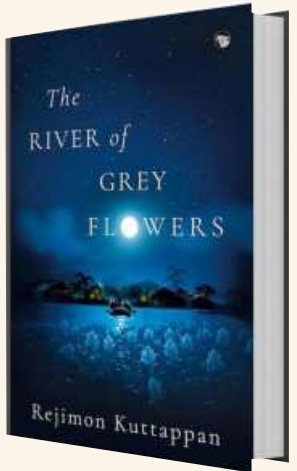
The author describes in minute detail life at the camp: the glare of fluorescent lights, the hawk eyes of the guards, rubbery dumpling dinners, and a brotherhood forged in cold, airless bunkers with slatted windows. Above all, there is the mind-numbing work.

Men forget time and space, their identities and lives back home. They forget to smile, to breathe, or eat, moving like zombies caught in a time loop with no beginning or end. Kuttappan's sparse, short

sentences slice through the darkness that shrouds the novel, effortlessly illuminating the narrative.

The story is told in the first-person narrative of John, and it feels personal. Before long, we are rooting for the young man who recently married the love of his life back home, and has to contend with sporadic, hushed calls from across the ocean. Kuttappan fuels the plot with taut, well-written action blocks. The punches, stabbings, scrambling in the dark, and bullets shooting dangerously past make the throat go dry.

An independent journalist who specialises in labour migration, Kuttappan has reported extensively on human trafficking and abuse of migrant workers. *The River*



The River of Grey Flowers
Rejimon Kuttappan
Speaking Tiger
₹499

of Grey Flowers is based on the real-life testimonies of people he was instrumental in rescuing from scam centres in Myanmar, Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam. And it shows – in the gut-wrenching details about men locked up in water dungeons, tortured on the dreaded 'tiger bench' and in their short, clipped conversations about home and family. Kuttappan describes the grey, lifeless compound as one that smells of sweat, metal, dust, and "something acidic – broken hope". An image that is sure to haunt us long after we turn the pages.



Workers rescued from scam centres in Myanmar wait at a detention facility. (AP)

BROWSER

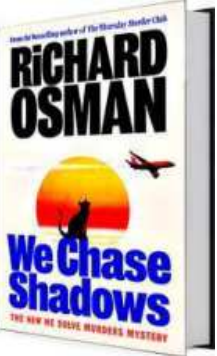
Taipei Story
Rebecca F. Kuang
Harper Collins
₹699

The bestselling author of *Katabasis* and *Yellowface* describes her new novel as a coming-of-age story in the "larky" style of Elif Batuman and Patricia Lockwood. It follows college student Lily over a summer abroad when questions of home and identity upend her.



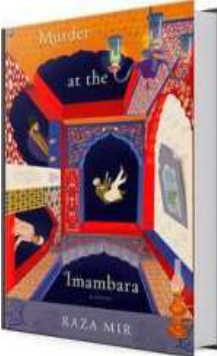
We Chase Shadows
Richard Osman
Penguin
₹999

A body is found on the steps of a private villa in Italy, marking the first official case for the investigative trio at the centre of Richard Osman's 'We Solve Murders' series. Best known for his *Thursday Murder Club* books, Osman has sold around 17 million copies worldwide.



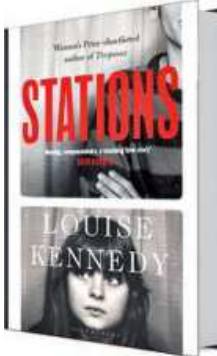
Murder at the Imambara
Raza Mir
Aleph Book Company
₹999

This prequel to Mir's 2021 novel, *Murder at the Mushaira*, is set in Lucknow, 1829. The hero is Mirza Ghalib, who witnesses a mysterious death during Muharram and is drawn into a dangerous conspiracy rooted in the Nawabi state.



Stations
Louise Kennedy
Bloomsbury
₹699

Following the success of her debut novel, *Trespasses*, which was adapted into a TV series, Kennedy brings her sharp, unsentimental prose to *Stations*, an intimate story exploring friendship, desire, class and the enduring scars of the past.





David Shulman brings to us stories of horror and terror from the South Hebron Hills, a rural area at the southern tip of the West Bank; (below) the author. (GETTY IMAGES, WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

Stanly Johny
stanly.johny@thehindu.co.in

The Israeli-occupied West Bank has been divided into Areas A, B, and C, as part of the Oslo Accords. The Palestinian Authority, based in Ramallah, has some security and civil administration powers in Area A, and civil authority in Area B, while the Israelis have full civil and military control over Area C, which covers 62% of the West Bank. Area C is home to some 3 lakh Palestinians and roughly 4.9 lakh Jewish settlers.

Modern Jewish settlements in the West Bank started soon after the 1967 war when Israel captured the West Bank and East Jerusalem from Jordan and the Gaza Strip from Egypt. Today, some 7.5 lakh Jewish settlers live in the West Bank and East Jerusalem. Over the years, the settler community has become politically powerful – they have their own parties and ministers.

The extremist, far-right sections of the settlers want to expel the Palestinians from their villages and grab their land. Israeli politicians have repeatedly called for annexing the settlements. In recent years, settlers in the West

SMALL ACTS OF RESISTANCE

David Shulman’s latest work explores Palestinian suffering in the West Bank and the importance of holding on to hope amid despair

Bank have stepped up attacks against local Palestinians, seizing their land, torching their homes, and unleashing physical attacks on them. It is these stories of terror and horror that David Shulman brings to us from the South Hebron Hills, a rural area at the southern tip of the West Bank, which is part of Area C, in his book, *Freedom and Despair: Notes from the West Bank*.

Driven by despair
Shulman, an Israeli scholar of South Asian languages and religion, has never shied away from critiquing what he calls the “monstrosity” of the Israeli occupation of Palestine. When this reviewer met him in January 2025 in Chennai, he said

“the army, the police, the military courts, the Israeli media, public and social media, and the government, which funds and supports the settlements, all constitute [the] system” that preserves occupation.

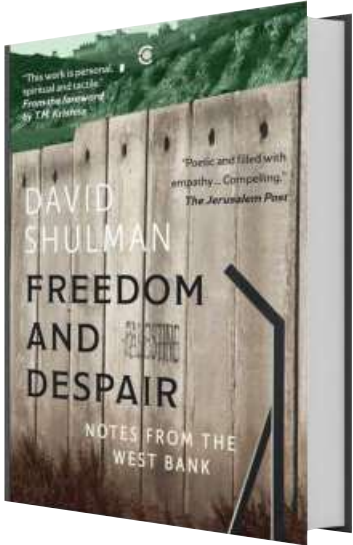
In *Freedom and Despair*, Shulman, who is also a member of Ta’ayush (co-existence in Arabic), an Israeli-Palestinian grassroots organisation, writes about the acts of resistance by Palestinians and Israelis against this machinery of occupation. Despite some micro victories, their acts do not have any meaningful impact on the larger political course. But despair – the state of having lost all hope – should not be an end in itself.

Despair, he writes, should act as a catalyst for more action, driven by “hopeless hope”.

Shulman is worried about both the victim and the aggressor, though on different scales. While occupation subjugates Palestinians to endless horrors, it transforms the occupier as well. “To impair the freedom of another people is to narrow one’s own self to a rude and bitter thing,” he writes. “For an entire people to impair the freedom is to multiply self-constriction exponentially.” Israel, according him, “has become ill and narrow at heart”.

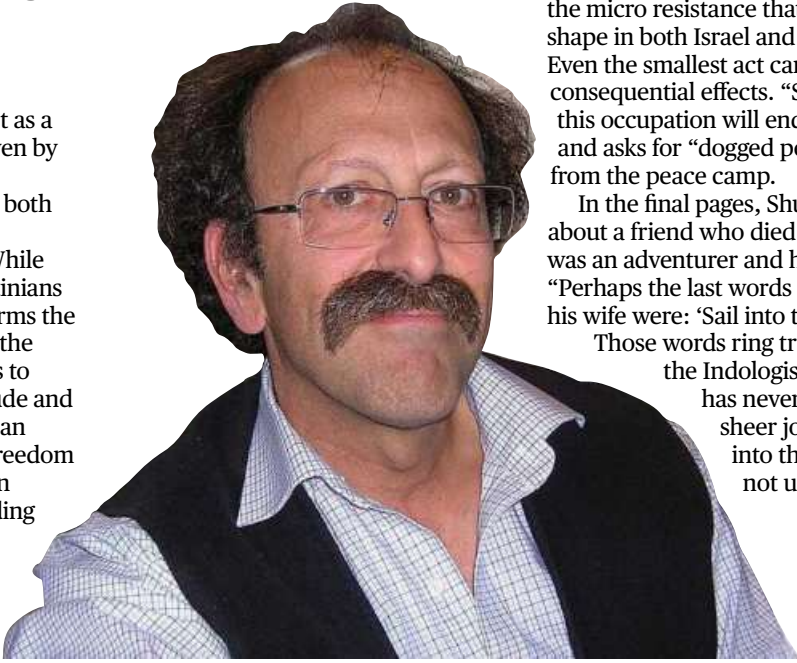
Ta’ayush, founded in 2000 during the second *intifada* (uprising),

Freedom and Despair:
Notes from the West Bank
David Shulman
Context
₹499



Shulman, an Israeli scholar of South Asian languages and religion, has never shied away from critiquing what he calls the “monstrosity” of the Israeli occupation of Palestine

works to end the Israeli occupation of Palestinian lands, stop racism, and build equal partnership between Arabs and Jews. At the micro level, the organisation has achieved a great deal: fields have been restored to owners, villages saved, homes rebuilt, and innocent Palestinians protected from arrest and torture. But Shulman also acknowledges that despite grassroots activism, Israel polity has shifted further towards the right,



imprisoning Palestinians in their deserts and on their hills. “There is a bitter contrast between the wide-open vistas of the desert and the utter absence of freedom to move, even breathe, that lies at the base of their experience,” he writes. “There are moments you could weep that human beings could be like this,” he adds while describing the settler violence against Palestinians.

Gandhian satyagraha
While despair is widespread, not doing anything is clearly not the answer. Shulman says the Jews had learned to overcome their deep passivity decades ago and rediscovered how to act in the world, defend themselves, and fight back. “Now they have to overcome the fascism that comes with blind autistic power: witness the settler, their primitive malice, their adoration of brute compulsion.” He quotes German-American rabbi and activist Joachim Prinz, who had first-hand experience of Nazi Germany in the 1930s, who said, “The most urgent, the most disgraceful, the most shameful, and the most tragic problem is silence.”

Shulman embraces Gandhian *satyagraha* – the non-violent assertion of a moral position – as the right way of resistance against the brutal machinery of occupation. Israeli generals and policemen prefer violent Palestinian resistance, which they can use as an excuse to tighten their control and occupation. “Violence compounds the evil. And besides, the beauty of Gandhian-style protest is that it needs no further justification. It is right in itself, worth doing for itself, for the sake of truth,” he writes.

Freedom and Despair is not just an account of the suffering of the Palestinians in the West Bank; it also offers a philosophical guidance to the micro resistance that is taking shape in both Israel and Palestine. Even the smallest act can have consequential effects. “Some day, this occupation will end,” he writes, and asks for “dogged persistence” from the peace camp.

In the final pages, Shulman writes about a friend who died young. He was an adventurer and historian. “Perhaps the last words he said to his wife were: ‘Sail into the wind!’”

Those words ring true, writes the Indologist. “One who has never known the sheer joy of sailing into the wind may not understand.”

Suresh Menon

We live in an era of oversharing: social media bombards us with personal details that can drive us to tears. The memoir, cringing when it is not boring, might become redundant. An autobiography is only to be trusted, wrote George Orwell, when it reveals something disgraceful. The opposite may be truer today. It is as if no life without child abuse or a murder in the family is worth writing about.

“It is no great pleasure to have lived,” wrote Lord Byron, “and less to live over again the details of existence – but the last becomes a necessity and even a duty.” In *On Memoir: An A-Z of Life Writing*, Blake Morrison comments, “The necessity is telling the story; the duty, to tell it honestly.”

It might be churlish to criticise a memoir. A stranger is laying out their life for us, and we must tread softly lest we crush it. They are saying either, “This is who I am,” or “This is who I wanted to be, so let’s pretend this is who I am.” Both reveal truths.

Life in a petri dish
Michael Cunningham’s 2024 novel *Day* begins thus: “If Wolfe were real, he’d be the elusive figure at the heart of the story.” Cunningham, an underrated writer despite the Pulitzer Prize for *The Hours*, is the elusive figure at the heart of his own story, *Unsayable: A Life in Writing*. He writes with a vividness that somehow manages to render the overall picture blurry, remaining just out of reach as a person although strongly present as a writer.

Cunningham places aspects of his life in a petri dish for us to better understand his fiction and

GETTY IMAGES/ I STOCK

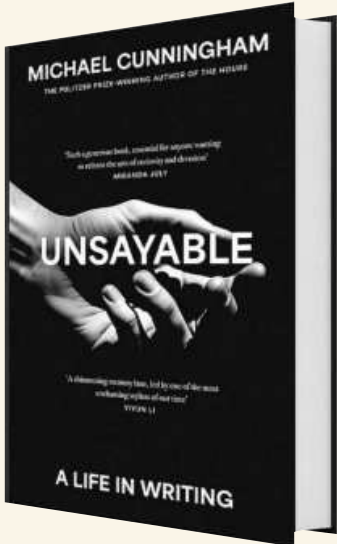


Writing about a life

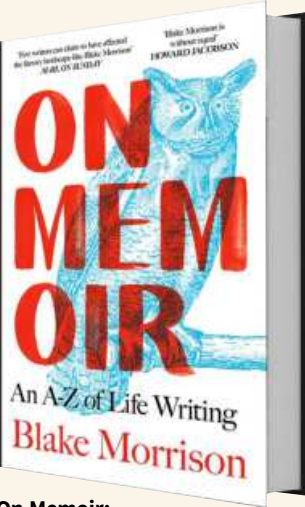
Michael Cunningham and Blake Morrison on memory and the making of a memoir

non-fiction. Sometimes it is difficult to differentiate between the two in some anecdotes – from the Tupperware story with which he begins the book, through his many gay encounters. Facts are the scaffolding on which higher truths rest, what Morrison calls “psychological truth and emotional resonance”. Cunningham believes that fiction is for getting at the truth

when the truth isn’t sufficient for the truth. “No story is purely, literally autobiographical, including autobiographies,” writes Cunningham, and asks, “Who’s the most reliable source about anyone’s past – the person who lived it, or the person who witnessed it? It’s probably both.” Morrison quotes English playwright Harold Pinter: “The real truth is that there is never



Unsayable: A Life in Writing
Michael Cunningham
Fourth Estate Ltd
₹899



On Memoir:
An A-Z of Life Writing
Blake Morrison
The Borough Press
₹1,927

any such thing as one truth...”

Memoir-writing can be the work of a lifetime. Ask Karl Ove Knausgård (six volumes), Ved Mehta (12), or Augusten Burroughs (eight). Writing on memoir-writing with clarity and joy while sharing a treasure chest of experiences is a distillation of a lifetime’s work.

The memoirist knows how the story began and where it will end; the best are aware of the distance in time and maturity between the person who experienced an event and the one writing about it years later. They know how to play on that tension without bringing a later knowledge to make a previous event seem inevitable.

Hindsight can connect the scattered dots of one’s life, but the memoirist should be careful not to pretend that the dots were always connected. Hindsight can make the past appear inevitable. Yet, a slightly different pattern imposed on the dots can be a literary version of the Butterfly effect when

a small change in an initial condition can lead to massive differences in later life.

The importance of shock
Much of the power of *Unsayable* is in the first three quarters of the book: it is when Cunningham reads Virginia Woolf’s *Mrs Dalloway* in school; when his actions in youth are detailed without embarrassment and connected to the writerly life. He takes the reader into confidence, lighting areas of his own soul, confident that what he did when young would not be held against the older person. Some of that electricity and shock leak out towards the end, however, with the connections sometimes appearing forced.

Shock is an integral part of the memoir, says Morrison, in a book that invites dipping in and out. Perhaps the most significant aspect of the memoir – as opposed to the novel – is that it is safe from AI, “which can’t speak authentically, in the first person as an embodied human being”, says Morrison. “Memoir tells the truth about a real life. And AI isn’t alive... when AI takes over literature, memoir will be the last genre standing.”

Memoir is more than what is said or unsaid; it is a record of the unsayable, of what language can and cannot do. Being fully aware of this, Morrison and Cunningham who are in their 70s, make for excellent guides on a young writer’s journey. All writing is a matter of choice, they seem to be saying – what to retain, what to leave out – and it does not matter whether it is fiction or nonfiction. The lessons are in the writing itself.

The reviewer’s latest book is ‘Why Don’t You Write Something I Might Read?’

INTERVIEW

HIGH RISK, HIGHER SAFETY

Australia's Indian-origin food safety researcher Sukhvinder Pal Singh on how India can address food adulteration

Dipanjani Sinha

Australia-based food-safety scientist Sukhvinder Pal Singh, whose roots hail from a family of farmers in Una, Himachal Pradesh, is a senior research scientist with the New South Wales Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development, in Ourimbah. Singh, 46, leads research on fresh-produce safety and traceability.

His work following Australia's deadly 2018 *Listeria* (bacteria in rockmelons) outbreak – which infected 22 people, killed seven, and caused a miscarriage – helped drive changes in horticultural food-safety practices. In 2025, he received the Australian Institute of Food Science and Technology's national Food Safety Award. Excerpts from an interview:

Question: How serious is food adulteration as a public-health problem in India and how does it hit the most?

Answer: Low- to medium-income households

are more prone to food fraud due to affordability and accessibility issues. While some adulteration is primarily an economic deception, some can create genuine health risks.

There is also a significant data and knowledge gap regarding population exposure to chemical contaminants, heavy metals, environmental toxins, microplastics and antimicrobial-resistant organisms through food and water. Comprehensive and easily accessible public data on the scale and cumulative impact of these exposures remain limited, while the long-term health consequences of some emerging contaminants are still not fully understood.

Q: Where is India going wrong in tackling adulteration?

A: A major weakness is the lack of a sufficiently systematic, intelligence-led and risk-based approach to food fraud and contamination. The system needs to identify food supply chains that are particularly vulnerable to adulteration,



Food-safety research scientist Sukhvinder Pal Singh. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

perhaps, top 10 high-risk, high-volume food categories and address them systematically. These could include milk and dairy products, spices, edible oils, meat and seafood, and fresh produce.

For each commodity, authorities should map the entire supply chain and identify where adulteration, substitution, contamination and temperature abuse are most likely to occur. Regulatory resources should be concentrated at these critical points, particularly bulk manufacturers, processors and distributors, rather than relying predominantly on end-point retail sampling.

Q: Can India make a noticeable difference without overhauling the entire food system?

A: India does not need to wait for a complete transformation of its food system before achieving meaningful improvements. It can concentrate resources on a manageable number of high-risk food chains, build safer behaviour from the household upwards, and prepare now for the growing pressures of heat and flooding. The objective should be to move from a system that predominantly detects problems after they occur to one that anticipates where the greatest risks will arise and intervenes before unsafe food reaches the consumer.

distributors, restaurants, street vendors and households, monitoring compliance at the final point of sale cannot adequately control risks that originate much earlier in the supply chain.

Q: What should India do immediately to control food adulteration?

A: First, make high-risk food chains safer through risk-based, intelligence-led enforcement. Rather than attempting to fix every part of an enormous and complex food system simultaneously, India should identify,

substitution, misleading labelling or contamination and determine where in the supply chain these risks are most likely to originate or occur at scale and who are the supply chain actors involved. Enforcement can become fragmented when it is overly concentrated on inspections and sampling at the retail end.

Q: Why isn't catching adulterated food at shops and markets enough?

A: Given the enormous scale and complexity of India's formal and informal food economy, from farms and *mandis* to processors,

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1



greater degree of traceability. But not all farms might reveal if any banned antibiotics, hormones, or steroids were administered to their cows/ buffaloes, for instance.

Finding the sweet spot In Kolkata, Partha Nandy, 42, has spent much of his life around milk. His family has owned Girish Ch. Dey & Nakur Ch. Nandy, the sweetmeat shop known for its *kada-pak* and *naram-pak sandesh*, since 1844. Nandy is its fifth-generation co-owner. The shop has maintained relationships with vendors for decades. Milk with added water produces less *chhena*. Adding milk powder for cost benefit produces low-quality, grainy *chhena*. During festivals, when demand for milk rises, these variations can become more common, he says.

Nandy adds he can also recognise impurities that appear during the preparation of *chhena*. The shop has historically relied on experience and relationships with suppliers rather than laboratory testing for adulterants. If there is something wrong with the milk, the vendor is warned. The problem, however, is that not every consumer is making sweets with it.



Testing times (Clockwise from below) Maharashtra FDA chief Tukaram Mundhe; Ashwin Bhadri of Equinox Labs; Equinox Centre main lab in Navli Mumbai. (PTI, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

“Check the date. Check the ingredients. Check the FSSAI number.” But exercise caution. An FSSAI licence or registration “establishes that the food business has entered the regulatory framework and is required to comply with its conditions but doesn't mean the regulator has laboratory-tested and certified the packet in your hand,” he says. The law places the larger responsibility on the business and the regulator.

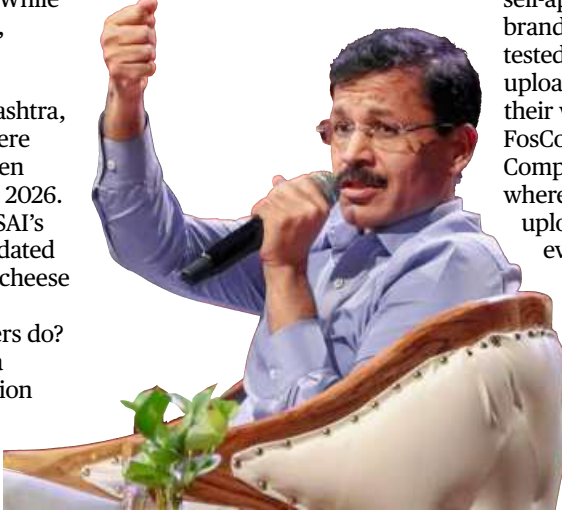
What the lab tells us The regulator and the laboratory have different roles, but the objective is the same: “safer food”.

Ashwin Bhadri, founder-CEO of Navli Mumbai-headquartered Equinox Labs, which tests food, water and air, recalls a large food-service business that

consumer has no equivalent way of investigating.

Paneer presents similar challenges. An August briefing from the Centre for Health Equity flagged dairy analogues being sold as paneer. While not inherently unsafe, passing these off as traditional paneer is misleading. In Maharashtra, 109 of 308 samples were non-compliant between April 2025 and March 2026. Consequently, the FSSAI's West Region has mandated accurate labelling for cheese analogues.

What can consumers do? Uday Kumar Saxena, a food-safety accreditation assessor and FSSAI-listed expert in risk assessment and analysis, says:



came to his laboratory concerned about the dairy product supplied to its kitchens. Tests showed it didn't meet the expected specifications and indicated manipulation.

Equinox Labs, which has been working with food manufacturers, QSR (quick service restaurant) chains and cloud kitchens, for the last 21 years across five cities, have, at times, asked food companies to remove or review claims such as “100% pure” or “100% natural” when unsubstantiated. The big change now, Bhadri observes, is that individual restaurants, clubs, cafeterias, hospitals, and schools are starting to reach out to them for auditing.

“The FSSAI and FDA don't care about intent. They care about the final outcome. Today, there are millions of SKUs (unique code or number to identify/ track products) in the market. One brand itself will have 50-100 different SKUs. FSSAI can't test every batch, the country doesn't have the budget or bandwidth,” says Bhadri. “One good idea FSSAI is to do is self-approval. They tell food brands to get their products tested by a third party and upload the quality reports to their websites. There's a FosCos (Food Safety Compliance System) website, where regulation mandates uploading quality reports every six months.”

The lesson for Bhadri is that testing needs to happen before the inspector, or the customer, discovers the failure. “A food company shouldn't discover a problem because an inspector



Bengaluru's elite circles use an app called FirstClub, launched a year ago, which runs all its products through a bunch of tests and only then lists them. The products aren't all that more expensive. The mass-y food aggregator apps can do these things. Since it's a huge loss for brands to not be listed on quick commerce, it could be a driving factor for change!

NANDITA IYER Doctor, food writer, content creator



Genuine mistakes happen sometimes but companies/ brands with a running history of false marketing claims, wrong labels, accuracy, misleading packaging, believe they can get away with it. Stop buying from repeat offenders and encourage others to boycott them

LUKE COUTINHO Wellness and lifestyle coach

found it,” he says. “It should discover the problem through its own quality-control system.” Testing, he says, should work as an

early-warning system rather than a compliance formality.

Price of awareness Another sample revealed microbiological contamination, including *Coliforms*, *Enterobacteriaceae*, *E. coli*, yeast, and mould. For an individual consumer, a food test at Equinox can cost between ₹500 and ₹25,000. A milk adulteration test may cost ₹1,000. A microbial safety test costs ₹1,500-₹2,000. A comprehensive panel covering pesticides, heavy metals and other tests can run into tens of thousands of rupees.

“Why should any consumer have to pay a premium merely to obtain food that is safe?” asks consumer-rights advocate Bejon Kumar Misra. A better-off consumer can choose an organised supermarket, a familiar brand or a subscription-based direct farm-to-home service. She can switch products when she loses trust. She can even pay for a laboratory test. “Money can buy more choices, but it cannot buy complete food safety,” adds Misra. Bhadri points to a section of society that does not read labels, or recognise food fraud when taste or consistency changes, and doesn't have the money or power to pursue a complaint. The inequality here is glaring.

Making the system work But here's the thing: “As an individual, you don't need to do this. Your job is simple. Just complain to FSSAI,” says Bhadri, mentioning that the Maharashtra FDA recently launched an AI portal to speed up food safety complaints, “where you literally talk and it will write the complaint for you”. The more privileged

Indians complain, the more it benefits all Indians.

In the last few months, Mumbaiers have been tagging the FDA on social media and checking before eating if restaurants and packaged foods have passed the “Tukaram Mundhe test”. Mundhe, who took over as Maharashtra FDA commissioner in May, has been busting profiteering food-fraud rackets, seizing adulterated and suspect milk/ dairy products, and suspending licences across the State. Mundhe's tenure illustrates what active enforcement can achieve – and its limits.

Can a suspect packet of milk/ paneer be quickly traced to the farm/ factory that made it and packaged it, revealing the ingredients used? So that consumers like Rajpurohit aren't compelled to test at home/ labs? That brings us to the question of accountability: who is responsible? The manufacturer, to ensure quality control. And the regulator, to inspect, test, penalise and enforce. While the laboratory can establish what is present in a sample, and the consumer can identify irregularities and complain, their job is only to notice and report, not inspect, test, investigate, prove or prosecute.

Bhadri doesn't believe in “more raids” but credits Mundhe for removing the “*chalta hai*” attitude. He says, “Enforcement is necessary, but enforcement alone won't fix the system.” The goal, as Bhadri puts it, should be to “make adulteration difficult to do, easy to detect, and costly to ignore”.

The writer is a Kolkata-based freelance journalist.



(Clockwise from left) Customers at HandpickedByPC farmers' market; harvesting apples in Tons Valley; Yashvi Mariwala; coffee harvesting at Nandan Coffee; snapshot of cold-pressed oils from the writer's pantry; and heritage rice by Edible Archives' new initiative, Edible India. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, SALAM OTTAYIL)



Customers of premium foods are a mixed bag. I have seen extremely well-off people, who would not blink at spending a lot of money on something else, balk at spending too much on rice. And I've seen those of middle-class backgrounds, like a young teacher, for example, who buys only indigenous rice or gets oil fresh from the oil mill

SHALINI KRISHNAN Founder, Edible Archives

Such buyers, however, remain relatively small and are concentrated in the country's bigger cities. “You have to be of a certain economic strata to go premium,” says Puneeta Chaddha Khanna, founder of HandpickedByPC, a farmers' market in Gurugram. “But it doesn't equate to wealth alone; it's also about awareness and exposure.”

Anand Sankar, co-founder of Sayb and Tons Valley Shop – which brought the people and produce of Uttarakhand's Tons Valley to the rest of India – is of a similar bent of mind. “There's a lot of interest in Tier 2 and 3 cities for our fresh



Food safety in India is in a very dangerous space right now. There is a huge trust deficit between the FSSAI, the farmers, the manufacturers, and the consumers. I also see customers with very varied states of awareness: some have in-depth scientific knowledge, while most are just WhatsApp aware

ANAND SANKAR Co-founder, Sayb and Tons Valley Shop

apples, unfiltered juice and clean label products, but it doesn't scale,” he says. “Populate it on a map and it looks we are selling across India, but 70% of our business comes from Mumbai and Bengaluru, followed by Chennai and the NCR.”

The price of 'better' A bottle of varietal honey from Two Brothers Organic Farms or Beez can go up to ₹900, as compared to ₹280 for 400 g from a big brand. A litre of cold-pressed groundnut oil costs ₹500, while mass market brands sell for around ₹195. Heritage rice sells for ₹300 a kilo, while its white rice equivalent starts from just ₹45. What exactly are consumers paying for?

Part of the answer lies in how these foods are grown and processed. Khanna, who is also an organic farmer, talks about the mustard oil she produces in small quantities. With few wooden presses available around Delhi-NCR, she sends her mustard seeds to Rajasthan

for cold-pressing, paying ₹120 a litre. The oil is then left to settle naturally for a month, leaving roughly 20% that she cannot sell. “That is why there is a premium attached to this,” she says. “It's the process, the wastage and the lower yield.”

Meanwhile, Yashvi Mariwala, co-founder of Nandan Coffee, an organic coffee company based in Kodaikanal, cautions against treating labels that command a premium as shorthand for quality. “There's always a risk of them becoming marketing buzzwords rather than meaningful indicators of quality,” she says. “Single-origin simply tells you where the coffee (or something else) comes from – it doesn't guarantee exceptional quality. Similarly, ‘organic’ speaks to farming practices, not necessarily flavour.” For consumers, the real test should be whether brands can back their labels with information about origin, processing, sourcing.

Is premium always healthier?

Does paying more necessarily mean eating better? “Some are healthier, some aren't,” says Delhi-based nutritionist and author Kavita Devgan. A bean-to-bar chocolate is still chocolate, just as no heritage grain or organic vegetables can compensate for a poor overall diet lacking proteins and fibres.

Cold-pressed oils, however, are one switch she believes has nutritional merit. Unlike refined oils that undergo high heat and extensive processing, these retain more of their naturally occurring antioxidants, vitamin E and plant compounds such as polyphenols.

Provenance is more complicated. “Knowing where a food comes from can offer greater confidence about its quality and authenticity, but does not automatically make it more nutritious,” she says. The challenge is to ask the right questions about food. Eating better may depend less on upgrading what is in the pantry than understanding what those upgrades actually deliver.

The writer is an independent journalist and photographer who covers travel, food, culture and sustainability.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty

WILDLIFE CONSERVATIONISTS OFTEN ADVOCATE FOR WILD APES LIKE ORANGUTANS AND GIBBONS TO BE ASSIGNED HUMAN RIGHTS AND PERSONHOOD.

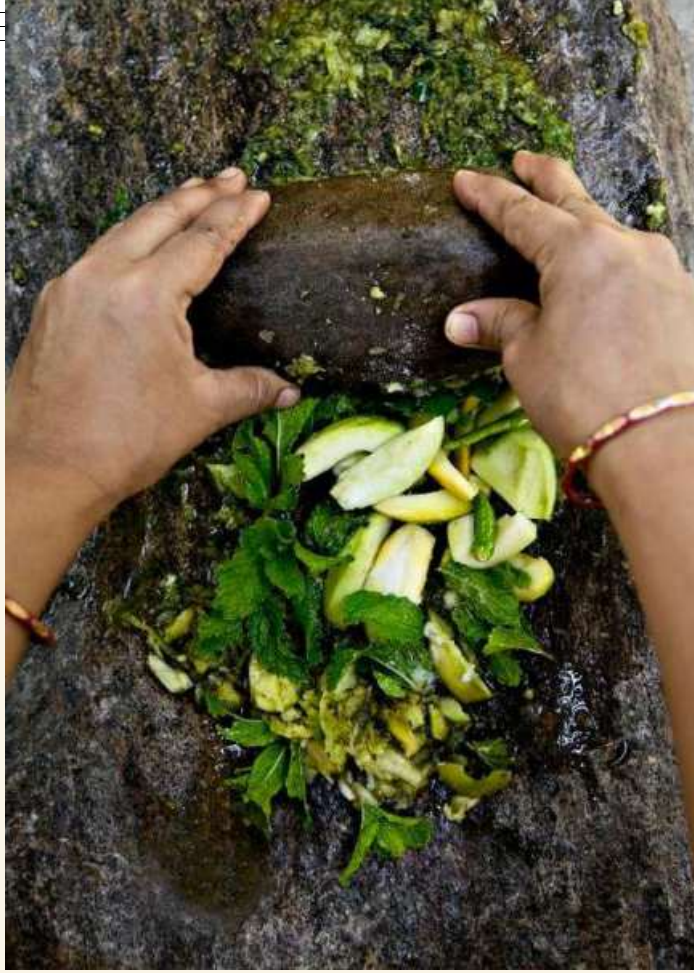


BUT I CAN ASSURE YOU THAT NO WILD APE WOULD WANT THE IGNOMINY OF BEING EQUATED WITH THE ONLY SPECIES IN THE WORLD THAT ENJOYS WATCHING ITS EVOLUTIONARY COUSINS LANGUISH IN CAPTIVITY.



MAYBE THE Homo Sapien SHOULD FIRST EARN APEHOOD BEFORE BESTOWING HUMANHOOD UPON OTHER BEINGS.

GETTY IMAGES



POP-A-RAZZI

We need a chutney map

Marginal on the plate yet ubiquitous, the chutney may be the ultimate unity-in-diversity dish

chutneys with your *idlis* and tea time chutneys with your *pakodas*, along with chutneys for lunch and dinner. This is the all-time unity-in-diversity poster dish.

But where are the chutney maps of India, the way we have mango maps and biryani maps? The chutney remains banished to the margins of the plate despite being such an ambassador of the breadth and depth of Indian cuisine. These “taste-bud openers”, as Nobel laureate Abhijit V. Banerjee calls the chutney in his foreword to Tilak's book, reflect the “true complexity” of Indian cuisine, “which comes from being able to build meals out of so many different tastes

and textures”. In fact, the most potent argument in favour of the chutney is that it does not make a *khicdi* of that diversity of tastes and textures in the name of unity.

Salman Rushdie coined the term “chutnification” in his groundbreaking 1981 novel *Midnight's Children* where he marvelled that the six hundred million eggs that gave birth to the population of India could fit inside a single, standard-sized pickle-jar, while the six hundred million spermatozoa would fit on a single spoon. “Every pickle-jar (you will forgive me if I become florid for a moment) contains, therefore, the most exalted of possibilities: the feasibility of

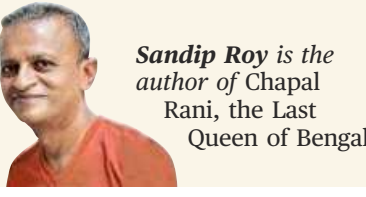
the chutnification of history; the grand hope of the pickling of time!”

Something for every taste In an essay in the *California Review of Books*, Brian Tanguay refers to the *Past Present Future* podcast, where host David Runciman situates *Midnight's Children* alongside books such as *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985) as one of our great political novels. Runciman is particularly interested in this idea of chutnification, writes Tanguay: “The process of blending many disparate ingredients into a palatable paste – as a way to think about the complex, messy and painstaking process of building a democracy, of bringing its baying voices and competing interests, feuds and schisms, grievances and hatreds, into coherent form.”

Perhaps at one time, the United States with its notion of the melting pot, kind of subscribed to that idea though a melting pot creates more of a stew than a chutney. But Donald Trump's America has resolutely moved away from that notion, putting out a more sliced white bread vision of who America is and who it belongs to. Trump is not alone in this. In many nations, election after election has seen the rise of political parties that view migration as a threat to local culture. They want stronger borders to keep the outsiders at bay.

Perhaps the old melting pot is now losing its efficacy as a symbol in such a world. Maybe what we need instead is the chutney, which can be sour or spicy or sweet or tangy, basically something for every taste. It exists on the margins of our plates, but somehow assimilates into the mainstream as ease like a model minority. And the chutnification of history does not flatten out its diversity.

Best of all, there is no one chutney to bind them all.



Sandip Roy is the author of *Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal*.

India does not have one Krishna, it has many. Each region, language, social class, and historical moment has shaped its own idea of who Krishna was, and what he meant.

Medieval Bhakti saints worshipped Krishna but they also reinvented him, through poetry, song, philosophy, theatre, and ritual. These Krishnas reflect local anxieties, political pressures, caste negotiations, gender ideals, and spiritual aspirations.

In Maharashtra, Chakradhar Swami (1194-1274 CE) offered perhaps the starkest Krishna. Founder of the Mahanubhava or Manobhava tradition, the Hindu philosopher rejected the playful, erotic Krishna of popular devotion. For Swami, he was a historical human incarnation, a perfected yogi, and a strict ethical exemplar. And Radha, the *gopis*, and the *rasa-lila* were all dismissed as corruptions. What remained was a severe Krishna and devotion meant obedience, moral rigour, celibacy, and mental restraint. This Krishna suited a community that valued renunciation, control of desire, and inward discipline in a time of political instability and social flux.

From tender guide to beloved lover
Barely a generation later, Marathi saint-poet Dnyaneshwar (1275-1296 CE) reimagined Krishna in radically different terms. In the book *Dnyaneshwari*, Krishna becomes cosmic consciousness and tender guide. An intimate companion and a metaphysical principle. The gap between *saguna* (having form) and *nirguna* (formless) collapses. This Krishna reflects a world less anxious about discipline and more interested



Vatapatrashayi miniature of Lord Krishna from Nathdwara, Rajasthan; and (far left) Krishna and *gopis*. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

He suits a devotional culture rooted in household piety rather than monastic withdrawal or philosophical abstraction. In Gujarat, Narsinh Mehta (1414-1481 CE) infused Krishna with social conscience. The poet's Krishna stands with the poor and the marginalised. The divine walks among leather workers, widows, and the oppressed, and devotion becomes empathy and ethical responsibility. Bhakti here becomes a critique of caste arrogance and ritual pride. This Krishna reflects Gujarat's mercantile world – its exposure to plural cultures and its concern with social harmony.

Divinity was never singular
Across these traditions, Krishna moves along multiple emotional axes. Each answers a different human need. Swami's Krishna restrains desire; Dnyaneshwar's dissolves the self; Sankardev's orders society; Mahaprabhu's intoxicates emotion; the Alvars' dramatises longing; Surdas' comforts the household; and Mehta's awakens compassion.

The many Krishnas of medieval India reveal that divinity was never singular or fixed. God was not an absolute idea imposed from above. Each community carved its own Krishna, reflecting its fears, hopes, struggles, and dreams. In doing so, medieval saints turned theology into anthropology, using Krishna not to escape the world, but to understand it more deeply.

Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

FROM CULT TO CULTURE

KRISHNA'S MANY FORMS

Must god represent just one idea? In medieval times, every region had its own version of the divine

and emotional collapse. Radha moves to the centre and the cosmic Vishnu retreats. What dominates is *madhurya bhava*, erotic mysticism, where devotion is intoxication and salvation is emotional union. This Krishna emerges from Bengal's lush agrarian landscape, its musical

culture, and its deep emotional expressiveness, transforming theology into aesthetic experience.

When god walked among us
Long before Mahaprabhu, the Tamil Alvars (the poet-saints from 600-900 CE) had already created an

emotionally charged Krishna. Writing in the voice of women longing for their beloved, they turned him into lover, child, king, and cosmic god simultaneously. The Alvar Krishna is emotionally vulnerable, and Bhakti becomes a theatre of passion, where divine and human emotions mirror each other. Their poetry shaped temple ritual, iconography, and theology across south India, creating a Krishna who cries, hides, seduces, and abandons, only to return again.

In the Braj region, devotional poet Surdas (1478-1583 CE) softened Krishna further, turning him into the mischievous child and tender cowherd. His poetry focuses on *bal-lila*, maternal affection, domestic intimacy, and playful charm. Krishna steals butter, breaks pots, teases *gopis*, and demands attention. Erotic mysticism exists but remains gentle and deeply affectionate. This Krishna enters kitchens and courtyards, and is emotionally accessible and human.

GOREN BRIDGE

Inspired play

North-South vulnerable, East deals

Bob Jones
South in today's deal was American expert John Schermer, who we believe is from the Seattle area. He covered the opening jack of diamonds lead with dummy's king, losing to the ace. East returned a diamond. Schermer played the 10, expecting it to be ruffed, but West followed with the five. Knowing that West started with short diamonds, Schermer decided not to play West for short clubs also. He

cached the king of clubs and led another club, picking up West's queen. What next?
Who had the king of spades? If West had it, Schermer could make his contract by leading toward the queen. Schermer decided, however, that East would not have bid four hearts on only three trumps and the ace of diamonds. He played East for the king of spades. Did that mean that the contract couldn't be made? Not at all! West's distribution was almost certainly 2-7-2-2. Schermer could make his contract if West held

NORTH
♠ Q 7 4
♥ K 10 3
♦ K Q 8 3
♣ A J 8
EAST
♠ K 10 8 5 3
♥ J 9 6
♦ A 7 6
♣ 6 2
WEST
♠ J 2
♥ A Q 8 7 5 4 2
♦ J 5
♣ Q 3
SOUTH
♠ A 9 6
♥ A void
♦ 10 9 4 2
♣ K 10 9 7 5 4

The bidding:
EAST Pass
3♥
SOUTH Pass
5♣
WEST 3♥
3NT
All pass

Opening lead: Jack of ♦
either the jack or the 10 of spades, or both. He cashed the queen of diamonds and led the queen of spades. East covered, Schermer played the ace, and West was under the gun. When West played low, Schermer led a

low spade and West was end-played. He had to give dummy the king of hearts. Had West unblocked the jack, Schermer would have crossed to dummy and led a spade toward his nine. Very nicely played!

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What's the motto with you?



In 2021, a word was formally added to the motto of this global sporting event, to make it: 'Citius, Altius, Fortius – Communiter' (Faster, Higher, Stronger – Together). (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley
Born on September 20, 1833, Ernesto Moneta was an Italian journalist who envisaged the creation of a league of nations, which led him to win the Nobel Peace Prize in 1907. His motto was 'In varietate unitas!' (Unity in diversity). This is now the motto of which supranational union of 27 countries?

British Army officer Robert Baden-Powell founded this movement, with an emphasis on guiding young boys through practical outdoor activities, self-reliance and leadership training. Its motto, 'Be Prepared', is often associated with Baden-Powell's initials, B-P. Which organisation is this?

On July 20, 2021, this organisation formally added one word to their motto, originally 'Citius, Altius, Fortius' (Faster, Higher, Stronger). Conceived by Dominican priest Henri Didon, the motto represents the ideals of the global sporting event. What event now has the motto 'Citius, Altius, Fortius – Communiter' (Faster, Higher, Stronger – Together)?

The national motto of India, 'Satyameva Jayate', is taken from a mantra in the *Mundaka Upanishad*. The relevant passage reads: "_____, not falsehood." What is the three-word motto?

On January 17, 1977, death-row inmate Gary Gilmore, moments before his execution, said, "Let's do it." His words

inspired Dan Wieden, co-founder of advertising agency Wieden+Kennedy, to create what iconic slogan for which sports company?

'Nullius in verba' ('Take nobody's word for it') is the motto of the oldest continuously existing scientific academy in the world. It reflects the organisation's commitment to establishing scientific claims through experiment and evidence. Which organisation is this?

'Inter Arma Caritas' ('In War, Charity') is the Latin motto of this humanitarian organisation, founded by Swiss businessman Henry Dunant, who was awarded the first Nobel Peace Prize in 1901. Which organisation, whose

emblem is the reverse of the Swiss flag, is this?

According to this character's fictional history, his family's Latin motto is 'Orbis non sufficit'. It's based on the actual family motto of Sir Thomas Bond, 1st Baronet, who was supposedly the character's ancestor. If the English translation is 'The world is not enough', which character is this?

This song, also known as YNWA, is a show tune from the 1945 musical *Carousel*. After Gerry and the Pacemakers covered it in 1963, their hometown football club adopted it as its anthem. Sung by fans to this day, the phrase has become closely associated with the club. Which club is this, and what does YNWA stand for?

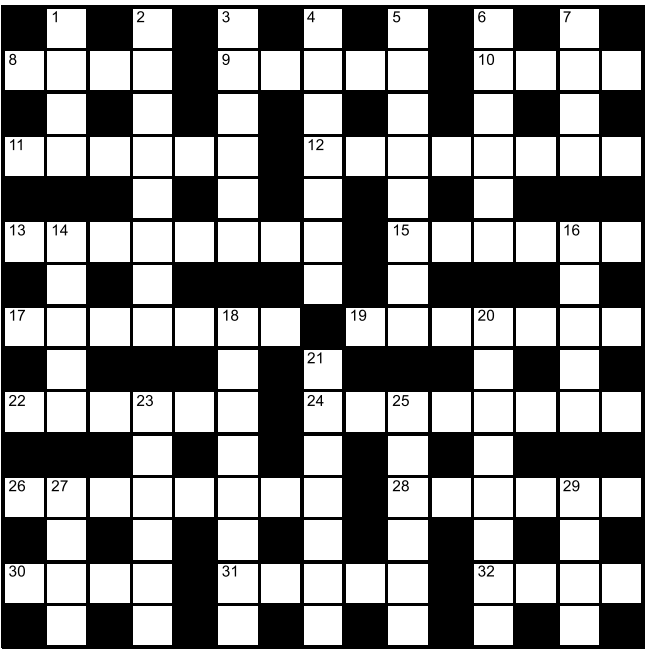
Featured in Them Mushrooms' 1982 Kenyan hit 'Jambo Bwana' and later adapted by Boney M. as "Jambo _____ (No Problems)", this Swahili phrase became a global catchphrase after *The Lion King* in 1994. What is the phrase, and what does it mean?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

10. Hakuna Matata – 'No worries'
9. Liverpool Football Club; 'You'll Never Walk Alone'
8. James Bond
7. International Red Cross
6. Royal Society
5. 'Just Do It'; Nike
4. Triumphs
3. The Olympic Games (scouts)
2. The Scout Movement (scouting; boy
1. European Union

Answers

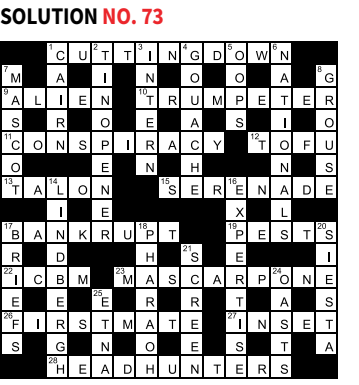
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 74 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
8 Initial exposure behind animal shelter results in eye problem (4)
9 Animal having desire to be accommodated in 10,000 square metres (5)
10 Gun held by East-Enders (4)
11 Boy retiring behind vehicle is one who wantonly damages property (6)
12 Wrongfully fill up as "Bucket-loads" (8)
13 Male creator redrew a kind of map projection (8)
15 Rang Charlie and Della on return (6)
17 Set aside book (7)
19 Girls follow college head's study sessions (7)
22 European ruler and a teetotaler, Ali is confused (6)
24 Egg preparation from East European motel having a piece of tomato (8)
26 Darkish sort, carrying duke's computer storage device (4,4)
28 King's wife is in clutches of devious adder (6)
30 Brandish wand to get sunrise (4)
31 Engaged in terminus evacuation (2,3)
32 Injured slow birds (4)

- Down**
1 Grain exported from Argentina transported for Sicilian summit (4)
2 Chief revolutionary has a migraine, for example (8)
3 Talk about the French summer hut used by herders (6)

- 4 Jumped parole taking dead animal (7)
5 Mad chap with Amnesty International rejected by California (8)
6 American fuel may be of assistance (6)
7 Power source in jail? (4)
14 First lady at book function (5)
16 Put in effort and uproot tree around ten (5)
18 Silly Vice Admiral drops ace for Putin, perhaps (8)
20 She gets redwood after dropping 28 in forest (8)
21 Calculate and exercise (7)
23 I... I love and feast... (6)
25 The Spanish girl gets name for cricket team (6)
27 A Washington Yankee is out (4)
29 River next to city bank (4)



Hospitality, not hostility, at Hormuz

Suryakumari Dennison
suryakumari.dennison@gmail.com

If my husband and I had foreseen that the Strait of Hormuz would dominate the news four decades after our stay in Iran, we might have paid closer attention to that strategic site. Actually, we had no excuse for ignoring it back then, for even in 1986, it was seething with unrest. During the conflict between Iran and Iraq, that volatile waterway was the scene of the infamous Tanker War, with both sides launching attacks on merchant vessels.

In retrospect, it seems strange that when hostilities were at their height, we visited Bandar Abbas, on the northern shore of the Strait of Hormuz. Of course, we wished to travel widely in Iran, but we were repeatedly cautioned against embarking on exploratory expeditions. Fighter jets, we were warned, could appear out of the blue. When it came to Bandar Abbas however, our friend Hossein rather recklessly disregarded the danger from air-raids. He was determined that we should spend a few days with him and his family in their beautiful port city.

Early one morning, Hossein picked us up from our home in Ahvaz, the capital of Khuzestan province, in southwestern Iran, and we set off on an exciting road trip of over a thousand kilometres. On the last lap of our journey, we drove along the coastline of the Persian Gulf until we reached our seaside destination after nightfall. We were warmly welcomed by Hossein's wife Fatemeh and their three children. They served us a sumptuous spread, laid out on a sofreh, a decorative oilcloth elegantly placed over a gorgeous carpet. We enjoyed not only the traditional dishes we had grown to relish but also some that were specific to the Hormozgan province, of which Bandar Abbas is the capital.

No military talk

Forty years have passed since we sat down to that feast. As psychologists have observed, memory is selective. That probably accounts for why my husband and I recall what we ate on that joyous occasion but not the happenings at Hormuz. Most likely, the latter was not the subject of our dinner discourse. Iranians rarely spoke about military matters, since careless conversations could land them in trouble. Though my husband and I were innocuous interlocutors, the crisis was off limits.

What we did discuss were Indian food, films, and fashion. Language was no barrier, as hosts and guests communicated in elementary English and faltering Farsi.

K. Aravamudhan
amudhan.ic@gmail.com

Last month, while heading for an official meeting during the first half of the day, I asked my driver to look for a shoe polisher nearby. It was still early, and after a few detours, he finally found one. It was a small tent under a tree, neatly organised and bearing all the signs of a busy cobbler's shop. Inside, hanging prominently on the wall, was a photograph of Lord Vishwakarma.

The man I was looking for, however, was nowhere to be seen. Perhaps, he had stepped away for his morning cup of tea. With time running short, I decided to wait. Just as I was about to leave, I spotted an old man waving from across the road. He hurried towards his shop, profusely apologising for keeping me waiting.

As I placed my shoe on the elevated stool, I noticed something that stayed with me. Before beginning his work, he removed his chappals outside the hutment. He then touched the photograph of Lord Vishwakarma with reverence and quietly settled down to polish my shoes.

It was an ordinary moment. Yet, to me, it seemed to capture an extraordinary India. Here was a man, probably belonging to the Baby Boomer generation, following a practice of reverence almost instinctively. He did not announce his faith, explain it or seek validation for it. He simply touched the photograph and got on with his work.

And there was an irony that was impossible to miss.

He was seeking the blessings of the deity he revered while repairing and polishing shoes inside the very same shop to earn his livelihood. His work was not separate from his reverence. His professionalism existed alongside his belief. In that brief moment, I saw a man who represented both reverence and professionalism. It also made me think about the India we are entering.

For generations, reverence has been woven into everyday life. It has existed in the way people greet elders, approach places of worship, respect teachers, celebrate festivals, and even begin their working day. Often, it has been expressed without words.

Not afraid to question

But India is now being shaped by generations for whom questioning is almost instinctive.

Gen Z and Gen Alpha are growing up in a fundamentally different environment. They have access to information before they have developed the patience to process it. They interact with people, cultures, and ideas across geographical boundaries from their phones. They are exposed to multiple perspectives, challenge hierarchies and are far less willing to accept something simply because it has always been done that way.

With reverence to a changing nation

Gen Z and Gen Alpha are digital natives growing up in an India that is more connected, aspirational, globally exposed than ever before



ILLUSTRATION: SURESH R. KUMAR

What older generations may describe as irreverence, younger generations may see as independence of thought. What one generation considers disrespectful, another may consider honest. And what one generation accepts as tradition, another may ask, Why?

This generational shift is particularly fascinating in India because our diversity has always been one of our defining characteristics. We have managed to coexist despite differences in language, religion, ethnicity, food, customs, and social practices. Now, perhaps, we are adding another dimension to that diversity: generational world view. Gen Z and Gen Alpha are not merely younger Indians. They are digital natives growing up in an India that is more connected, aspirational, and globally exposed than ever before.

They consume content differently. They discover brands differently. They build communities differently. They communicate differently. Even their relationship with authority, institutions and tradition is changing. Yet, perhaps the mistake would be to see this as a battle between reverence and irreverence.

The old man at the roadside reminded me that India has never really been about choosing one over

the other. He could touch the feet of his deity and, moments later, work with complete professionalism. There was no contradiction in his mind. As we move towards celebrating 100 years of Independence, the country is already a continental-scale paradox – diverse, contradictory, resilient, and constantly evolving.

The founding fathers could not have anticipated Gen Z and Gen Alpha becoming another defining layer of that diversity. Nor could they have imagined a generation that would challenge conventions with the confidence of having the entire world in its pocket. But perhaps that is the beauty of India. Every generation believes it is changing the country. And somehow, India absorbs the change without losing itself. The old cobbler, standing beneath a tree, touching the photograph of Lord Vishwakarma before polishing a stranger's shoes, offered me a quiet reminder of that resilience.

Maybe the future does not belong entirely to reverence or irreverence. Maybe, like the man I met that morning, India will simply find a way to practise both – with reverence for what shaped us, and enough irreverence to question what should change. Knowing India's resilience, I am confident this too will pass.

Vivek K. Agnihotri
vkagnihotri25@gmail.com

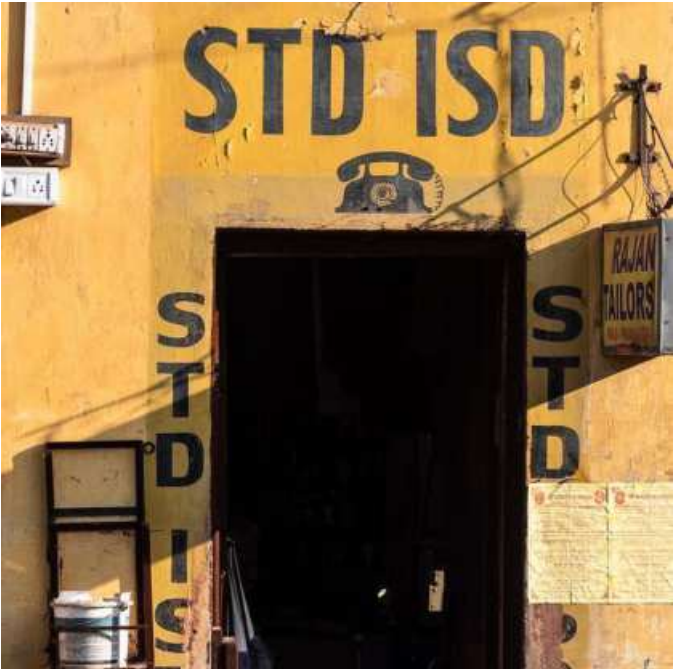
The occasion was an engagement ceremony. A three-year-old daughter of the bridegroom's elder brother had a piece of advice for her grandfather's sister, whom she called *bua* because her father called her by that appellation. The tiny tot said: "*Bua*, now that my *chachi* is coming, you have to move over." Move over Gen X, Y, Z. Welcome on board Gen Alpha.

More than 70 years ago, as a child, I saw my father use a special soap cake, in a branded case, to lather his face for shaving. By the time I had come of "shaving age", the soap cake had been replaced by shaving cream. In due course, shaving gel and foam had emerged as potent competitors.

My father had an official telephone at home, and to make a call, one had to go through the telephone exchange. To make an inter-city call, then known as a "trunk call", we had to go to a post office. After booking the call, one had to wait indefinitely for it to "mature". Then came the era of STD (Subscriber Trunk Dialling). By adding the city code to the telephone number of the receiver, one could talk to the person concerned. The introduction of mobile phones made things much easier. You

Future is not ours to see

Change, led by technology, is the only constant even within a generation



Dialling in change The public call offices vanished with the advent of cheap mobile telephony. GETTY IMAGES

can even make a video call and a conference call.

My father used to buy petrol by gallons (approximately 3.8 litres to a gallon) for his car. Each gallon cost a rupee and a quarter. A seer of milk (roughly equal to a litre or 9.33 grains, or 0.6 grams, in weight) cost the same, so did a packet of 10

Capstan cigarettes, my father's favourite. Today, petrol is ₹100 or more a litre; milk is ₹60 or more; and a packet of 10 Capstan cigarettes is ₹90 or more.

In the my school canteen, everything, from a samosa to a cup of tea, cost one aana (six paise). Thus, one could get 16 of them for a rupee. Today,

you would be lucky if you could get either of them, in a roadside dhaba, for less than ₹10.

Originally, there was the much-loved radio with an array of knobs. My siblings and I spent quite some time with it listening to cricket commentary and Binaca Geetmala. Then came the more popular portable "transistor radio". The scenario changed completely with the introduction of television. First it was only in black and white, with only a few hours of programmes on a single government-run channel. Today we have hundreds of colour channels, mostly private, running 24x7.

For writing, one used a pen-holder with replaceable nibs. This instrument used to be dipped in an ink bottle, time and again, to continue writing. Then came the fountain pen. A later version had a tube, which sucked in the ink from the bottle. The tube was replaced by a cartridge, in due course. In the meantime, ball-pens have become universal.

That brings to mind the ubiquitous typewriter. I first saw it in a small room of a PA to an officer. It looked huge,

When the desktop was introduced in offices, it was treated with a lot of respect. Shoes had to be taken off before entering the computer room

and filled the room like the original computer. Now, only a sophisticated version of its keyboard remains to be seen everywhere.

The computer was popularised through desktops, followed by laptops and palmtops. Now, the mobile, loaded with a speech-to-text app, does most of the work. External storage devices have gone from the humble floppy (a few kilobytes) to diskettes, CDs, pen drives, and hard discs (in terabytes).

When the desktop was introduced in offices, it was treated with a lot of respect. Shoes had to be taken off before entering the computer room. Sometimes, cloth slippers were provided to be worn instead. The computer room was air-conditioned. There was, therefore, a race among officers to place the computer in their room, along with the operator, of course.

The computers, coupled with the Internet revolution and advances in Information and Communication technologies, have created a mind-boggling scenario. Today, social media rules the roost: for good or bad. Humanoids play football, robots perform intricate operations, and drones do patrolling for security and surveillance. Then there is AI, the flavour of the day chatbots, such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, and our own home-grown Sarvam. It is all so 'perplexing'.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The feminist movement in India shows that change rarely depends on one celebrated leader. ('Who is the Gloria Steinem of India?'; Sept. 13) Grassroots groups have sustained struggles over land, labour, caste, and violence for years. Institutions should support such collectives with funding, training and legal assistance.

A. Myilsami

Lost gem

The review's discussion of a changing Lucknow raises a larger question about preserving urban heritage. ('Lost in Lucknow'; Sept. 13) Historic neighbourhoods and monuments need documentation and public access. Conservation should not freeze cities in the past, but redevelopment should respect cultural memory.

Durga Arunkumar

Miscommunication era

Designed as a personal communication application, WhatsApp has since evolved into a business communication platform and is increasingly being used to circulate rumours and hate speech. ('When forwards become facts'; Sept. 13). Books such as this play an important role in raising awareness and encouraging critical and responsible engagement with social media.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Freedom to express

Feminism shouldn't impose a dress code or behavioural standard. ('Can feminists have shaped eyebrows'; Sept. 13) Schools, workplaces and media organisations can help by treating women's choices with

respect. Freedom means allowing different expressions without demanding an ideological explanations.

K. Sakunthala

Food for thought

The proposed maze of examinations, clearances and permits is deliberately absurd, yet it makes a point. ('Licence Raj for laughs'; Sept. 13) As regulation expands, accountability must follow too. Authorities should rely on existing laws for unlawful conduct and protect lawful satire. A predictable framework would serve performers and audiences better than bureaucratic permission.

S.M. Jeeva

G. Sampath again demonstrates a skilful mastery of sarcasm. His gentle, harmless jabs deliver body blows to our criticism-averse establishment. Hats off to his creative approach.

Kamal Laddha

Farewell to an icon

Yayoi Kusama's ability to make a simple motif widely accessible shows the value of public engagement with art. ('The woman behind the dots'; Sept. 13) Indian museums and galleries should take similar work beyond the cities through travelling exhibitions, affordable entry and archives.

S.P. Suganya Devi

Art mirrors life

The filmmaker's focus on marginalised lives and migration shows why cinema needs space for unfamiliar stories. ('Anupama Roy: turning escape into art'; Sept. 13) Regional languages and working-class experiences deserve support beyond film festivals.

Swathi Senthilkumar



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Where time stopped

A first-hand account of the devastation caused by the Nepal floods

Prabhat Khanal

When the healers need healing

Medical literature describes healthcare professionals affected psychologically as 'second victims'

Rishi Kanna

Memories that bring a smile forever

Unexpected help from strangers is an unforgettable occurrence

Thayyil Sethumadhavan

A dirge for rainy days in schools

With easy commuting, the fun is missing

Skand Shukla

Contributions of up to a length of 700 words may be e-mailed to: openpage@thehindu.co.in Please provide the postal address and a brief background of the writer. The mail must certify that it is original writing, exclusive to this page. The Hindu views plagiarism as a serious offence. Given the large volume of submissions, we regret that we are unable to acknowledge receipt or entertain queries about submissions. If a piece is not published for eight weeks please consider that it is not being used. The publication of a piece on this page is not to be considered an endorsement by The Hindu of the views contained therein.

HOMO FABER 2026

THE FUTURE OF HANDMADE

A powerful lesson from British artist Es Devlin's *An Island of Light* in Venice is how exhibition design can change the perceived value of an object



Rosella Stephen
rosella.s@thehindu.co.in

At a time when AI bosses are making headlines, warning that their machines may become too powerful to control, Venice is a city of hope. With its quiet argument for handmade and human intelligence, be it at the Venice Biennale, Homo Faber or the zillion art and design shows across the city, it provides a winning case for where human agency should remain. On the island of San Giorgio Maggiore, Homo Faber 2026 unfolds under British artist and scenographer Es Devlin's keen direction, across workshops, cloisters, a labyrinth, a mirrored hall and a swimming pool. It is a celebration of things made slowly and deliberately and by people who have spent years learning the craft. But in his opening speech, Alberto Cavalli does not dismiss technology; he calls it a tool. As

executive director of the Michelangelo Foundation, Cavalli oversees this biennial exhibition of contemporary craftsmanship (running September 1-30, 2026). "If you go to an artisan's workshop, they have many tools, but they will not use a hammer if they have to use, you know, scissors. Every tool has its own function," he says, drawing a line at the moment the tool begins to replace human ideas and talent. Meanwhile, Devlin wants visitors to the exhibition to understand that "artisan thought" happens through the fingertips. During an interview with a handful of journalists, she says it is vital not only to think with the cerebral cortex but to "think through the body". In this fourth edition of Homo Faber Biennial, Devlin's *An Island of Light* features about 700 exceptional objects, 500 artisans and more than 70 countries, across 15 unforgettable installations. More than 40 of the artists and ateliers are from India,



Our *karigars* are, in every sense, India's living heritage. It was this belief that led us to create the JSW Prize for Contemporary Craftsmanship: to celebrate their artistry and place Indian craftsmanship firmly on the global map

SANGITA JINDAL
Chairperson, JSW Foundation



Clockwise: Es Devlin at *A Full Moon Rising*; Alberto Cavalli; Rooshad Shroff's *Balance* vase; Sangita Jindal; and *A Luminous Ark*. (MICHELANGELO FOUNDATION)

including Ankon Mitra and Shalini Mithal, Gunjan Gupta, architect Rooshad Shroff, and the designers Vikram Goyal and Tarun Tahiliani. Supported by the JSW Foundation, Indian crafts are represented across the show, and it is a pleasure to find them holding their own, sometimes outshining their neighbours. You can spend hours ruminating over the objects in any one room or go back over several days to soak up Devlin's immersive theatre. A few to get started:

● **A Full Moon Rising:** Clearly the standout. Nico Daswani from the Michelangelo Foundation rightly says that this is the installation he would get right to if he were "coming in from outer space". Installed

in the Fondazione Giorgio Cini's former swimming pool, it turns the Korean moon jar into a global craft vocabulary: ceramics, paper, glass, metal and other handmade vessels are arranged on a semicircular structure that slowly emerges from the water, creating the illusion of a moon rising over the lagoon.



● **An Alphabet of Objects:** More than 200 handmade objects sit on a kinetic structure and backlighting throws their silhouettes onto the walls, turning vessels and sculptures into something resembling an ancient visual language. It also makes the human hand unusually visible indirectly, through the complexity of the silhouette.

● **An Infinite Birdsong:** An enclosed, mirror-filled environment in which handmade birds and insects, including jewel-like interpretations, multiply seemingly without end.

● **A Great Turning:** This instantly recognisable image, of Devlin's enormous two-axis



The collaboration with the JSW Foundation and the Jindal family has helped me approach contemporary Indian craftsmanship with a good eye. I think tradition or heritage is not the worship of ashes, but the preservation of fire, to borrow from composer Gustav Mahler. And this is very important when you look at a country like India with a population that is very young, a country that is not a country but a continent with so many faces, cultures, identities

ALBERTO CAVALLI
Executive director,
Michelangelo Foundation

kinetic mirror mosaic rotating over shallow water in the Palladian Cloister, is what you get back to often. It reflects the architecture, sky and sunlight back into itself. It references the Venetian history of broken mirror fragments, and marries modern machinery with the ancient monastery.

● **A Feast of Light:** A strong craft-and-curation showcase, where the Palladian refectory is transformed into an almost monochrome banquet table of porcelain, glass, paper, textile, marble, mother-of-pearl and even Lego, all brought together by a single vertical shaft of light.

The writer attended Homo Faber as a guest of JSW Foundation and the Michelangelo Foundation.

Ranvir Shah

As you drive towards the Chettinad region in southern Tamil Nadu, the landscape gradually gives way to dry shrub. Palmyra trees line the farmlands, their spoked leaves casting shadows on the tar road. Large tamarind trees shed their fruit, which crunches under the tyres of passing cars. Over the years, the Chettiar community has settled here, building a formidable network of trade and commerce across India and Asia. It is a small and proud community. Today, its members are scattered all over the world, from the U.S. to Europe to Southeast Asia, yet their ancestral homes remain in Chettinad, in their natal villages. And they return, almost like homing pigeons, for festivals, weddings and death ceremonies. With the men often away for extended periods, they built vast residential compounds enclosed by high walls and filled with numerous rooms for their joint families to live in. Within these walls, Burma teak was intricately carved with deities; kitchens were stocked and food prepared with whatever was in season, with provisions carefully stored to last through the dry summer months. Today, there is a growing effort to preserve this extraordinary heritage through the M.Rm.Rm. Cultural Foundation, led by the visionary Visalakshi Ramaswamy, a committed Chettiar revivalist deeply



Inheriting Chettinad

A vibrant new museum chronicling Chettiar life looks to connect ancestral traditions, global journeys, craft and future generations

conscious of the fading traditions of her community. "While working on the book, *The Chettiar Heritage* (with co-authors S. Muthiah and Meenakshi Meyyappan), my job was to photograph the homes. Over the four years we put the book together, I saw so many Chettinad homes being broken down, their things sold, and so many elders who were guardians of the tradition dying," she says. **Documenting a community** Ramaswamy has been passionately involved in the

restoration of traditional crafts such as palm-leaf basket weaving (*kottan*), Chettinad sari-weaving (*kandangi*), Chettinad lime plaster, and the now-ubiquitous Athangudi tiles – almost mandatory in a South India-inspired space. Her approach to it, however, has been rooted in understanding before intervention. And she has taken this philosophy forward with the newly opened Museum of Chettinad. Housed in Ramaswamy's 125-year-old family home in Kanadukathan, the museum is

Heritage tour (Clockwise from left) The ancestral home in Kanadukathan that houses the Museum of Chettinad; and the various artefacts on display. (R. VENGADESH)



a culmination of her years of research into the Chettinad way of life. "Once when a group of visitors arrived, I took my husband's grandmother's things and, with whatever knowledge I had, put on an exhibition for them in the attic. It stayed there for many years. Soon, people began coming to me for more information. I decided that I would answer all their questions through a

museum and that's how we now have the Museum of Chettinad," says the 80-year-old. The museum visit begins with the history of the Nagarathar community – the myths of its origins, and the reasons why the community came to settle in this particular region. Visuals of community temples and festivals offer an introduction to the traditions that continue to bind the community together. Moving through the rooms, one learns about the Nagarathars' routes of commerce, migration and religion. The home museum's traditional architecture also becomes a part of the story, allowing the various crafts that play an integral role in Chettiar domestic life to be seen in their original context, rather than as isolated objects in display cases. **The domestic life** One of the first rooms curated by Ramaswamy was a

collection of Raja Ravi Varma prints, seen in homes across India. Here, however, the gods and goddesses depicted in the prints are partially covered with cloth and embroidery – one of the first things you see when you enter a Chettiar home. It was also a pastime of the Chettiar women, or *aachis*. Women have been the cornerstone of the community, as important to its continuity as the men. In many ways, some of the most compelling stories are to be found in the subtexts of the displays. The Chettiar homes were almost minor fortresses, organised and run with great efficiency by the women who remained behind while the men travelled for trade. We move to the rooms that reveal the rhythms of domestic life. Kitchens, storerooms and galleries are filled with everyday utensils, grinding stones, copper water heaters and large storage jars – the paraphernalia required to feed large families and host elaborate festivals. Other rooms are dedicated to basket weaving and the classic Chettinad sari, a delightful interplay of colours, checks and stripes, set off by contrasting borders and *pallus* in cotton and silk. There are collections of colourful imported enamelware and Burmese lacquerware, used for both everyday and special occasions. Beautifully lit found furniture and display cases sit against walls painted in Chettinad's vivid palette of magenta, emerald and terracotta – the colours of its landscape and architecture. Finally, we arrive at a

gallery devoted to festivals, marriages and ceremonies marking seniority, each accompanied by distinctive jewellery and carefully observed traditions. It would be a spoiler to reveal more. **Keeping memory alive** Having worked with several young people, students and arts colleges over the years, Ramaswamy has built a core team that can carry forward the museum and the Foundation's activities. The intention is not simply to preserve a disappearing past, but to create a model for curating community museums that hold both tangible and intangible histories – and that have the capacity to evolve. The Chettiars, who traded across the world, were global citizens long before globalisation became a way of life. Each room at the Museum of Chettinad, while inviting curiosity, reflects years of detailed study into Chettiar traditions. "We hope that all written and published information on Chettinad and the Nagarathars, by anyone, will be collected here. The museum will become a repository for stories of this community, from across the world. Perhaps several generations from now, someone will come looking for information on their forefathers – it will be available here in so many ways," says Ramaswamy. *The writer is a cultural activist, philanthropist, and founder of Prakriti Foundation.*